

LEAP Business Plan

Team AJT

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Executive summary

- ▶ Leap; the AJT E-commerce prototype web-app, is a flexible, college-oriented ,online merchandise platform designed to generate sustainable revenue, uplift schools/clubs, and create an inclusive local community.

By leveraging e-commerce technology, print-on-demand fulfillment, and strategic marketing, Leap will establish a scalable retail presence that serves students, alumni, faculty, and fans. (Marroquin et al.)

AJT's E-commerce web-app aims to make set up easy and accessible to both schools and academic clubs looking to increase revenue while boosting school spirit.

Highlights

Product	POD Base Cost (Printful/Printify)	Market Low (Amazon/generic)	Market Mid (Bookstore)	Market High (Premium drops)	Recommended NSC Price	Est. Margin
Classic T-Shirt	\$7–\$12	\$15–\$18	\$28–\$35	\$40–\$50	\$28–\$35	50–60%
Pullover Hoodie	\$22–\$28	\$25–\$35	\$45–\$60	\$65–\$90	\$50–\$60	45–55%
Hat / Cap	\$10–\$16	\$18–\$22	\$25–\$35	\$40–\$55	\$28–\$38	50–60%
Tote Bag	\$8–\$12	\$12–\$18	\$20–\$28	\$30–\$45	\$22–\$28	55–65%
Mug / Drinkware	\$8–\$14	\$14–\$20	\$22–\$30	\$35–\$50	\$24–\$30	50–60%
Backpack	\$25–\$40	\$30–\$45	\$50–\$75	\$80–\$120	\$55–\$70	40–50%

(Marroquin et al.)

Mission statement

- ▶ We are looking to make merch sales accessible to a wider variety of colleges and their student groups.
We're interested in making the service available to both clubs and schools alike.

Key to success

- ▶ Opening the services to not only schools but also to clubs and student groups will set our product apart from what's currently available on the market.

Problem & Solution

- ▶ Leap will contribute to the easy and straight forward start to merch sales for any college or student group looking to generate revenue for their school/club.

We want to make start up as accessible as possible, as to allow schools and student groups to start selling merch with ease to them and without the burden of excessive cost.

We hope to help foster community amongst schools and student groups by making start up accessible.

Location

- ▶ Direct online sales will serve as Leap's primary revenue driver through the e-commerce storefront, open to students, alumni, faculty, and the public. (Marroquin et al.)

The service will exist entirely online.

Products and services

- ▶ In practice we are looking to use a Print-on-Demand Model:
“Partnering with suppliers such as Printful or Printify to eliminate upfront inventory risk.

- Products are printed and shipped only when an order is placed.

Bulk & Event Orders

The site in future could also support in-bulk for campus orientations, graduations, sports games, and college events at discounted wholesale pricing.

Seasonal Limited Drops

The site may create urgency and repeat purchases through limited edition collections tied to homecoming, holidays, and graduation season.” (Marroquin et al.)

Start-up/acquisition summary

- ▶ “Estimated Costs to Develop and Launch

Based on a launch budget of \$15,000 to \$50,000, below is a breakdown of anticipated startup costs across all major categories.

- E-Commerce Platform (Shopify or WooCommerce)

\$500 – \$2,000 per year. Covers monthly subscription, domain registration, and SSL certificate. Shopify is recommended for its ease of use and scalability.

- Website Design & Development

\$3,000 – \$8,000. Includes storefront design, mobile optimization, product page setup, and checkout configuration. A professional designer ensures a polished, on-brand experience.

- Initial Inventory

\$5,000 – \$15,000. Covers the first production run of core items such as shirts, hoodies, hats, backpacks, and accessories. Print-on-demand reduces this cost significantly if adopted from the start.

- Branding & Logo Design

\$500 – \$2,000. Professional design of the logo, color palette, and brand guidelines to ensure consistent visual identity across all products and marketing.

- Photography & Product Mockups

\$500 – \$1,500. High-quality product photography and digital mockups for the website and social media. Strong visuals directly impact conversion rates.

- Marketing & Launch Campaign

\$2,000 – \$5,000. Covers social media advertising, campus flyer campaigns, influencer outreach, and a launch event or giveaway to generate initial buzz.

- Payment Processing Setup

\$200 – \$500. Configuration of payment gateways including Stripe, PayPal, ApplePay, and credit card processing with proper security protocols.

- Shipping Supplies & Packaging

\$500 – \$1,500. Branded boxes, mailers, tissue paper, stickers, and packing materials for a professional unboxing experience that reinforces the brand.

- Contingency & Miscellaneous

\$1,000 – \$3,000. Reserved for unexpected costs, software add-ons, refunds, or mid-launch adjustments.

Total Estimated Launch Range: \$13,200 – \$38,000 — comfortably within the \$15,000– \$50,000 budget with room for growth” (Marroquin et al.)

Marketing

Market analysis



According to our industry research, "the collegiate licensing market tops \$4.6B annually in the U.S., with apparel comprising approximately 62% of that total value." (Marroquin et al.) The platform will reach

institutional clients through direct outreach to college administrators and partnerships with student government associations.

Market segmentation

- ▶ The target market segments into three tiers: community colleges, four-year universities, and student organizations. Community colleges and student organizations represent an underserved segment, often lacking the budget or technical resources to launch merchandise operations independently. These groups prioritize ease of setup over advanced features, making them ideal early adopters.

Competition

- ▶ Direct competitors include campus bookstore operators such as Follett and Barnes & Noble College, online marketplaces like Fanatics, and custom merchandise platforms like Custom Ink. Indirect competition comes from DIY solutions where students create designs independently and order through services like Printify. Leap differentiates by offering a turnkey solution that reduces setup costs while allowing institutions to maintain brand control and capture revenue directly.

Pricing

- ▶ Industry benchmarks suggest retail pricing of \$28–\$35 for t-shirts and \$50–\$60 for hoodies, yielding gross margins of 45–60% depending on product category. (Marroquin et al.) Institutions set their own retail prices above the base production cost.

Advertising and promotion

- ▶ In addition to the social media and campus marketing outlined in the Start-up summary, client acquisition could include direct outreach via email to college administrators or possibly LinkedIn. Campus brand ambassadors offer a cost-effective channel for grassroots awareness within student networks.

Strategy and implementation

- ▶ The initial rollout prioritizes building a functional prototype demonstrating core e-commerce capabilities. Early adopter institutions will provide feedback to refine the platform before broader marketing efforts.

Appendix



Citations:

Marroquin London, Keaton Phaedra Fingold Jonathan/Jack. “NSC MERCH STORE White Paper & Minimum Viable Product (MVP) Plan.” 2026. Microsoft Word file.

Marroquin London, Keaton Phaedra Fingold Jonathan/Jack. “INDUSTRY & COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS NSC Merch Store” 2026. Microsoft Word file.